

The Noble Ritual of the King of Rites of Amoghapāśa

Ārya-Amoghapāśa-kalparāja-vidhi-nāma · Toh 689 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་དཔོན་པོའི་ཞུགས་པའི་རྩལ་ཆེ་གོ

Toh 689 in the Kangyur is a ritual text known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-Amoghapāśa-kalparāja-vidhi and in Tibetan as "The Noble Ritual of the King of Rites of Amoghapāśa," which may be rendered into English as the Noble Ritual of the King of Rites of the Lasso of Unfailing Benefit. It belongs to the tantric section of the Kangyur and sets out detailed liturgical and recitation procedures centered on the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara and his celebrated Amoghapāśa dhāraṇī, a powerful mantra associated with liberating beings from suffering and securing the fruits of awakening. The text is framed as a discourse in which the noble Avalokiteśvara addresses the Buddha and undertakes to reveal this elaborate ritual for the universal benefit and happiness of all beings, with the rite itself described as having been honored and praised by all buddhas. It appears to function as a companion or appendix to a larger Amoghapāśa cycle, since its opening lines indicate that it concludes the benefit and ritual section of the dhāraṇī of the Tenth Ground.

This is the ritual of recitation, showing that the buddha's awakening is unsurpassed. Here ends the benefit and the ritual section of the dhāraṇī of the Tenth Ground.

In the language of India: Ārya-Amoghapāśa-kalparāja-vidhi-nāma. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Ritual of the King of Rites of Amoghapāśa.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara, Lord of the World, addressed the Blessed One with these words:

Blessed One, today, for the benefit of the many, for the happiness of the many, out of tender love for the world, and out of compassion for all beings, I shall proclaim this very ritual — fine and detailed — of the King of Rites of the Lasso of Unfailing Benefit, which has been honoured and praised by all buddhas and bodhisattvas in the midst of the retinue's maṇḍala. Please give your assent.

Oṃ padma hasta mahā amoghapāśa sahāyaṃ samaya hrdayāṃ cara cara hūṃ.

This is called the heart-essence of Avalokiteśvara in his intrinsic nature as the Lasso of Unfailing Benefit, and with it all activities are accomplished.

Oṃ divya sampūraṇaṃ ge viloki kṣaṇi hūṃ.

This is the vidyā of the ringing hand-bell. When it is recited twenty-one times, sentient beings are liberated from the lower realms by the power of its sound.

Oṃ patra pūraya amoghavato samanta prabhe svāhā.

This is the vidyā of the begging bowl. When it is recited twenty-one times, the contents are transformed into nectar, and all who partake of it are liberated from the lower realms.

The mudrā is formed by pressing the palms firmly together, then drawing them apart into the lotus position, with the index fingers shaped like a jewel. The middle fingers are bent slightly inward — this is the mudrā of the pinnacle of the great banner of the wish-fulfilling jewel. With the hands placed upon the crown of the head, this empowerment vidyā is recited seven times:

Oṃ trai dhā anugata, abhiṣiñcatu māṃ sarvatra iya dhvike padmamaṇi supadme amoghe sarva tathāgatāya adhiṣṭhite hūṃ.

By receiving empowerment through this vidyā alone, the mantra-holder is empowered by all the Tathāgatas. Noble Avalokiteśvara himself bestows the empowerment. One becomes a great king among mantra-holders. All mantras are accomplished. All afflictive obscurations are completely purified. Without any doubt, one comes to abide as the sole sovereign lord of the world.

Oṃ padmoṣṇīṣa vimale hūṃ phaṭ.

Blessed One, a son or daughter of good family who, with compassion, makes this ten-syllable heart-essence of the secret mantra their own and recites it will become irreversible from awakening, and from there will advance to abiding on the Tenth Ground. Gods and human beings alike will say of such a person, "This one is a Tathāgata," and they will become irreversible from unsurpassed and perfect awakening. They will become a wheel-turning sovereign of the stainless crown of the lotus of Amoghapāśa — of this there is no doubt. Blessed One, know that this ten-syllable heart-essence of the secret mantra is endowed with immeasurable great qualities.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, it is so. It is indeed so. Son of good family, if even reciting these heart-essences of the dhāraṇī mantras syllable by syllable, one by one, performs the activity of a buddha — then what

need is there to speak of those who, with full dedication and with the greatest effort and exertion, recite and practise and accomplish them in full accordance with the ritual?

This stainless heart-essence of the wrathful dhāraṇī mantra of the lotus crown of Amoghapāśa — the great secret mantra of ten syllables, unfolded in sequence — if even once a sentient being merely calls it to mind, or reads it aloud, or takes hold of even its name alone, or simply recalls it on some few occasions, then all the karmas of that sentient being — even those that were bringing that being to fall into the Avīci hell to dwell there for an eon, as a result of having committed the boundless karmas — all those karmas shall be entirely purified. All evils and all obscurations shall be exhausted of themselves. The body shall become thoroughly pure and stainless. All obscurations and all mental afflictions shall be entirely abandoned. And after death, that being shall be born by miraculous arising from a lotus in the world-realm of Sukhāvatī. In all future lives, that being shall remember its past births. It shall never go to the lower realms. For eighty billion eons it shall become supreme as a wheel-turning monarch. It shall travel from buddha-field to buddha-field. And it shall be cherished by the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. This is the rite of practice.

Then the Blessed One declared to Vajrapāṇi, Lord of Secrets: Vajrapāṇi, this stainless secret heart-essence of the root mantra — the lotus crown of Amoghapāśa — whatever son or daughter of good family who holds this vidyā mantra, or monk, or nun, or layman, or laywoman, in whom even a single recollection of it arises in the mind, and who, with a nature of perfect purity, is endowed with great compassion and loving-kindness of heart, and with a noble intention does not abandon any sentient being whatsoever, and who with focused attention recites it into the ear of any sentient being whatsoever — those sentient beings shall not be born in the lower realms. That is utterly impossible. All those sentient beings shall also come to be endowed with great roots of virtue. If it is recited twice, all illnesses shall be thoroughly pacified. If it is recited three times, all fevers, pustules, abscesses, tumours, fire-sores, scabies, skin diseases, and all forms of leprosy shall be thoroughly pacified. If it is recited four times, all poisons, stick-poisons, harmful spells, and injuries inflicted by enemies shall be thoroughly pacified. If it is recited five times, all strife, disputes, conflicts, and calamities shall be thoroughly pacified. If it is recited six times, all fears, all spirit-possession, all epidemics, and all harm from adversaries shall be thoroughly pacified. If it is recited seven times, all

untimely deaths, all harm inflicted by sentient beings, and all plagues and contagious diseases shall be thoroughly pacified.

Vajrapāṇi, therefore, for the sake of all sentient beings, one should recite this heart-essence seven times each day without speaking other words in between.

Vajrapāṇi, there are those who commit the ten non-virtuous and evil deeds most thoroughly, who commit the boundless karmas, who reject and slander the sacred Dharma, who utterly despise noble persons — and at the hour of death they are on the verge of falling into the hells. And there are monks who have torn the vows of their training, whose vows of moral discipline are shattered and destroyed, who are disrespectful and ungrateful toward their preceptors and teachers, who wound the sacred Dharma — and at the hour of death they too are on the verge of falling into the hells. For the sake of all these beings, one should recite this heart-essence seven times over pure sand, then scatter that sand onto a corpse abandoned in a charnel ground, or onto the bones of a cremated corpse, or onto a corpse placed in a charnel stūpa, or onto bones. And in whatever place the bones of any sentient beings are found, one should scatter that sand over them, and immediately upon the scattering —

— all the sentient beings upon whom that sand has fallen, even if they have already been reborn in the hells, as hungry ghosts, as animals, in the birthplaces of flesh-eating spirits, or in the birthplaces of yakṣas — at that very instant they shall pass from that life, and all of them shall be carried upward into the higher realms, into the worlds of gods and humans. And from that time forward they shall never again be born in the destinies of hell-beings, hungry ghosts, or animals.

If this very dhāraṇī mantra of ten syllables is written on birch bark, cloth, or paper and placed inside a stūpa, then all living creatures — two-legged, four-legged, many-legged, or legless — that come anywhere near that place shall be completely purified of all their misdeeds and obscurations merely by being touched by the shadow of that stūpa, and they shall be carried upward into the higher realms. Deer, birds, foxes, dogs, mongooses, insects, snakes, tortoises, creatures that move on their bellies, and all other small animals that wander in the shadow of that stūpa — all of them too shall be entirely purified of all their misdeeds and obscurations merely by being touched by that shadow, and all of them shall be carried upward into the higher worlds.

If this mantra is recited seven times over a conch shell and similar objects and that conch is then blown from the summit of a high place, then all those — men, women, boys, girls, gods, hungry ghosts, or those belonging to animal births — who hear the sound of that conch shall be carried upward into the happy higher realms of the gods. They shall meet with virtuous spiritual friends, hear the Dharma, and shall gradually progress until they attain nirvāṇa.

Those sentient beings who delight in generosity, who dwell in the practice of fasting observances, who have taken refuge in the Three Jewels, who are endowed with perfectly pure moral discipline, and who are properly bound by the bodhisattva vow — if they hear that sound, all of them shall become irreversible from awakening and shall swiftly and fully awaken to the highest, unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. Immediately upon passing from that life, they shall be reborn in the world-realm of Sukhāvatī.

If this mantra is recited seven times over white sandalwood and the incense is then burned in the assembly hall of the Saṅgha, in a storehouse, amid a great gathering of people, or in a royal palace, then all sentient beings who carry that fragrance upon them shall be completely purified of all the obscurations of karma and affliction, and this shall continue until they fully attain the perfect body of a buddha.

If a Dharma robe is thoroughly fumigated with this and then worn upon the body, all that person's misdeeds and obscurations shall be entirely and without remainder purified. By that robe merely falling upon the body, all stains of habitual tendencies, all faults of miserliness and affliction shall be abandoned. By fumigating a robe and carrying it, the entire world shall come under one's sway. If one's robe is thoroughly fumigated and one enters a royal palace, both the king and his queens shall come under one's sway. One shall become a great object of veneration for all. One shall become the teacher of the entire world. If one enters into the midst of the noble Saṅgha, one shall become a great object of veneration for the entire Saṅgha. If one enters into a great assembly of ordinary people, one's wealth and great possessions shall increase, and one shall likewise become worthy of being a great object of veneration.

This concludes the ritual of sandalwood incense.

This is the fourth chapter, "The Heart-Essence of the Immaculate Lotus Crown," from the Tantra of the Amoghapāśa.

Now shall be fully expounded
the tantra of the great king of wrathful ones.

In the wondrous life of Amoghapāśa, the great king,
all siddhis are obtained without obstacle,
and through empowerment bestowed in every maṇḍala,
all enmity is utterly vanquished.
The hosts of māras and obstructing spirits are completely destroyed.
Yakṣas, rākṣasas, and keepers of secrets —
all elemental spirits flee in terror.
Every aspiration is brought to perfect fulfillment.

Oṃ bhṛkuṭidaṃṣṭre amoghā samaye abhiṣiñca māṃ sarva-vid amogha aṃ
abhiṣeka hūṃ mili mili svāhā.

This is the heart-essence of the king of wrathful ones.

Now follows the ritual of the sacred image. In silver, one fashions the great king of wrathful ones — twelve finger-spans in height, exceedingly beautiful and of perfect proportion, with three faces and a crown of wild, upswept hair. The crown of his head is adorned by the Victor Amitābha. He bears a crescent moon upon his head. The first of his three faces is wrathful; the right face wears a slight smile; the left face is laughing. He has four arms. In the upper right hand he holds a lotus; in the lower right hand he raises a sword aloft. In the upper left hand he holds a lasso; in the lower left hand, a three-pronged spear. Adorned with all ornaments, he is seated in the royal posture upon a lotus-and-moon seat. His lower body is wrapped in the skin of a fierce wild beast.

To his right stands the goddess Tārā, holding an utpala lotus, perfectly adorned with all ornaments. To his left stands the goddess who is the queen of awareness-mantras, holding a precious jewel, perfectly adorned with all ornaments. Before Avalokiteśvara, the lord of the world, kneels the mantra-holder, holding an incense vessel and a counting rosary, gazing upward toward the Blessed One. Alternatively, these figures may be painted as a painting, in accordance with the ritual.

The surfaces of these images are anointed with balm of myrrh. A maṇḍala of white sandalwood is prepared, and saffron is offered as a water-offering. Flowers and the like are offered in complete and proper worship. Upon this maṇḍala the great king of wrathful ones is invited to be present, and one thousand eight hundred recitations of the mantra are performed before him.

Thereupon the image will begin to stir and move. It will take steps back and forth with its feet. Rays of light will issue forth from the image. It will emit words. It will utter the sound "Excellent!" The right hand will be placed upon the crown of the head of the mantra-holder. Everything one has thought in one's mind, and all supreme attainments, will be perfectly fulfilled.

At the moment the recitation is complete, the noble Avalokiteśvara, the lord, the great king of wrathful ones, will be present before one. At the mere moment of calling him to mind, all siddhis will be accomplished. All activities will be performed. Through the recitation, all activities and all siddhis will be accomplished, and all attainments will be made manifest.

Taking hold of the lasso of the great king of wrathful ones and performing one thousand eight hundred recitations, all merit accumulated in the past and every portion of one's karmic share will become directly manifest. Until the very end of one's life one will obtain great splendor and experience greatness.

Gazing directly at the face and performing one thousand eight hundred recitations, one will obtain the siddhi of the great lord of power.

Taking hold of the lotus and performing one thousand eight hundred recitations, one will be freed from all afflictions and secondary afflictions.

Taking hold of the sword and performing one thousand eight hundred recitations, one will obtain the siddhi of traveling through the sky.

Taking hold of the three-pronged spear and performing one thousand eight hundred recitations, one will become lord over the three worlds, and all beings will come under one's power.

Taking hold of the waist and performing one thousand eight hundred recitations, one will remember one's former lives. Kings, queens, and their retinues will come under one's power.

For as long as one lives, wealth will remain close at hand. Performing one hundred and eight recitations while holding the crown, and then binding it to the head of the wrathful king, one will assuredly obtain empowerment. In this, one should not give rise to doubt or wavering.

Through these recitations and practices, the noble Avalokiteśvara in the form of the wrathful king will come before the holder of the awareness mantra and perform whatever is needed.

Here ends what was extracted from the ritual of the noble Amoghapāśa, the King of Examinations.

This was translated by the paṇḍita Mañjuśrīvarma and

Translator's Notes

- The phrase rendered as "sole sovereign lord of the world" translates "jig rten gyi gtso bo gcig pu'i gnas," which literally means "abiding as the sole chief of the world," a conventional epithet suggesting supreme spiritual authority rather than temporal rulership.

The ten-syllable heart-essence mantra is a well-known condensed dhāraṇī of the Amoghapāśa cycle; it is not spelled out explicitly in this passage beyond the count of syllables.

The closing rhetorical construction "what need is there to speak of" is a classical Sanskrit figure of speech (kim uta) carried faithfully into Tibetan and here rendered accordingly.

- The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text, so the translation likewise ends at the point of interruption. The continuation clearly describes the immediate effect of scattering the blessed sand, which is presumably given in the next passage.

The term rendered "stick-poisons" translates a compound that likely refers to poison administered by striking or applied weapons; the precise medical or cultural referent is uncertain but the general sense of "poison through physical means" or "weapon-poison" is clear from context.

- The phrase rendered "dhāraṇī mantra of ten syllables" follows the Tibetan ཐུགས་ཀྱི་མཚན་ལྟར་བཤད་པའི་མཚན་ལྟར་, which refers to a specific ten-syllable mantra that has been the subject of the preceding instructions. The exact identity of this mantra within the Amoghapāśa cycle would require consultation of the Sanskrit text for certainty.

The closing verse couplet introduces a new section; "the tantra of the great king of wrathful ones" renders ཐུགས་ཀྱི་མཚན་ལྟར་བཤད་པའི་མཚན་ལྟར་, which is a chapter or sub-tantra dealing with a great wrathful king deity, likely Caṇḍamahāroṣaṇa or a similar figure within the Amoghapāśa textual cycle.

- The mantra line is rendered as found in the Tibetan phonetic transcription, preserving the Sanskrit as given. The original text's Sanskrit is somewhat irregular orthographically, but the rendering follows the Tibetan phonetic syllables faithfully.

The expression "taking hold of" each body part or implement of the image refers to the meditational or ritual act of grasping that part of the visualized or depicted form during recitation — a standard tantric instruction for directing the power of the siddhi toward a specific result.

- The text ends mid-sentence with the colophon naming the paṇḍita Mañjuśrīvarma, indicating that the names of the Tibetan translator collaborators follow in the next line, which is not included in this passage. The title rendered as "King of Examinations" reflects the Tibetan "rtog pa'i rgyal po," a standard epithet within the Amoghapāśa ritual cycle referring to the sovereign or supreme tantra of that cycle; it could also be rendered "king of the deliberative" or "sovereign among the analytical," but "King of Examinations" best fits the ritual-tantra context here.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.